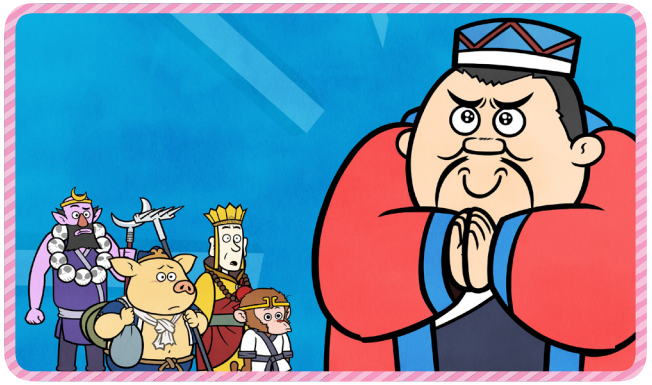
Little Fox Readers

Level 5

Journey to the West 99
Squire Kou's Vow



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Little Fox

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The monster yelled from inside the cave. "We ate the Tang Monk! So you might as well leave!"

"Oh no!" Bajie fell to his knees and cried.

Wujing wiped tears from his eyes. "Poor Master."

Wukong frowned at his companions. "I can't believe you two believe that monster." He sighed. "Wait here."



The monkey turned into a moth and flew into the cave. He soon found the Tang Monk tied up in a dark room. Wukong turned back into himself.

"Wukong!" cried the Tang Monk.

"Shh." The monkey untied the monk. "We must be quiet."

Wukong recited a spell. A moment later the sound of snoring drifted into the room.

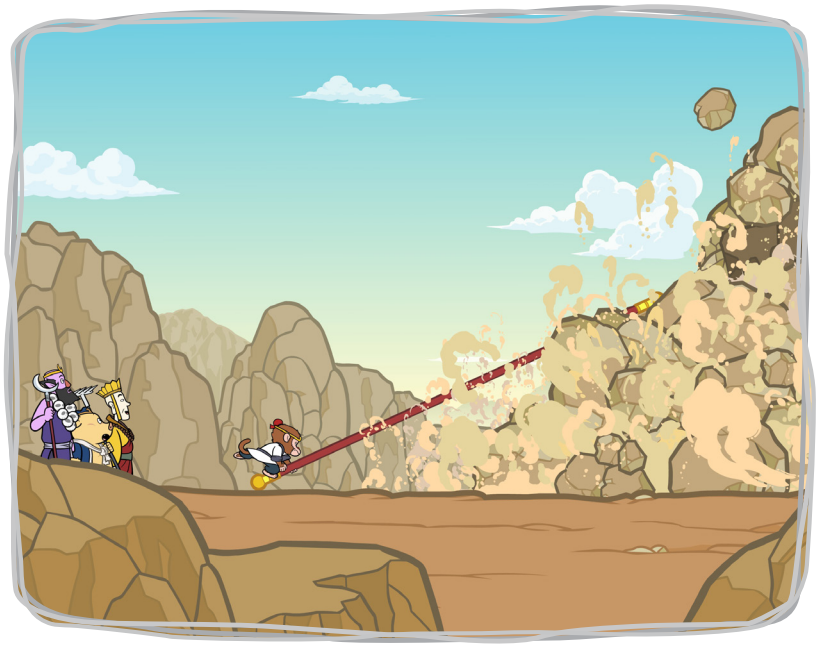


“My spell put the monster and demons to sleep,” said the monkey. “Let’s go.”

Wukong and the monk came out of the cave. Bajie and Wujing were thrilled.

“Master, we thought you’d been eaten,” said Bajie.

“I knew he was fine,” said Wukong. “Now I’m going to make sure these villains never bother anyone again.”



He pulled out his iron bar. It grew until it was the size of a very tall tree.

“Stand back,” said the monkey.

With one swing Wukong smashed the entire cave. Rocks exploded and fell on top of one another.

Wukong looked at the rubble and smiled.

* * *



Weeks went by, and the travelers arrived in a small town.

Bajie's stomach growled loudly.

Wukong laughed. "I guess we should look for food."

They saw an old monk walking down a street.

"Kind monk," said the Tang Monk. "Do you know where we can beg for some food?



We are quite hungry."

The old monk nodded. "Go to Squire Kou's house. The squire made a vow to feed ten thousand Buddhist monks. He will surely give you some food." He gave the Tang Monk directions to the house.

"Thank you," said the Tang Monk.

The travelers arrived at the squire's gate, and a servant let them in. The squire's house



was very large and fancy.

Squire Kou came outside. “Greetings,” he said with a smile. “Please come inside.”

The travelers sat with the squire in a large room. A servant brought tea and snacks.

“Thank you for inviting us in, Squire,” said the Tang Monk. “We heard that you made a vow to feed ten thousand monks.”

“Yes,” said the squire. “I’ve made plenty



of money during my life. But I want to do good deeds as well. I hope to be reborn one day as a bodhisattva or even a buddha.”

“Well, Squire,” said Bajie, “today’s your lucky day! I can easily eat as much food as ten thousand monks. So if you feed me, you’ll definitely become a buddha!”

Everybody laughed.

“It *is* my lucky day,” said the squire. “Last



night I checked to see how many monks I've fed. So far I've fed 9,996 monks. I need to feed only four more in order to fulfill my vow." A smile spread across his face. "And there are four of you!"

That evening Squire Kou held a feast. Everybody in the town was invited.

The travelers sat with the squire and his wife, Lady Kou.



Bajie drooled as he gazed at all of the wonderful food on the table. "Noodles, buns, mushrooms . . . I don't know what to eat first!"

As they ate, Squire Kou leaned toward the Tang Monk. "So where are you and your companions going?"

"We're traveling to the Western Paradise," said the monk. "We're going to fetch the True Scriptures from Buddha."



The squire’s eyes lit up. “You are special guests! I can’t let you leave!”